

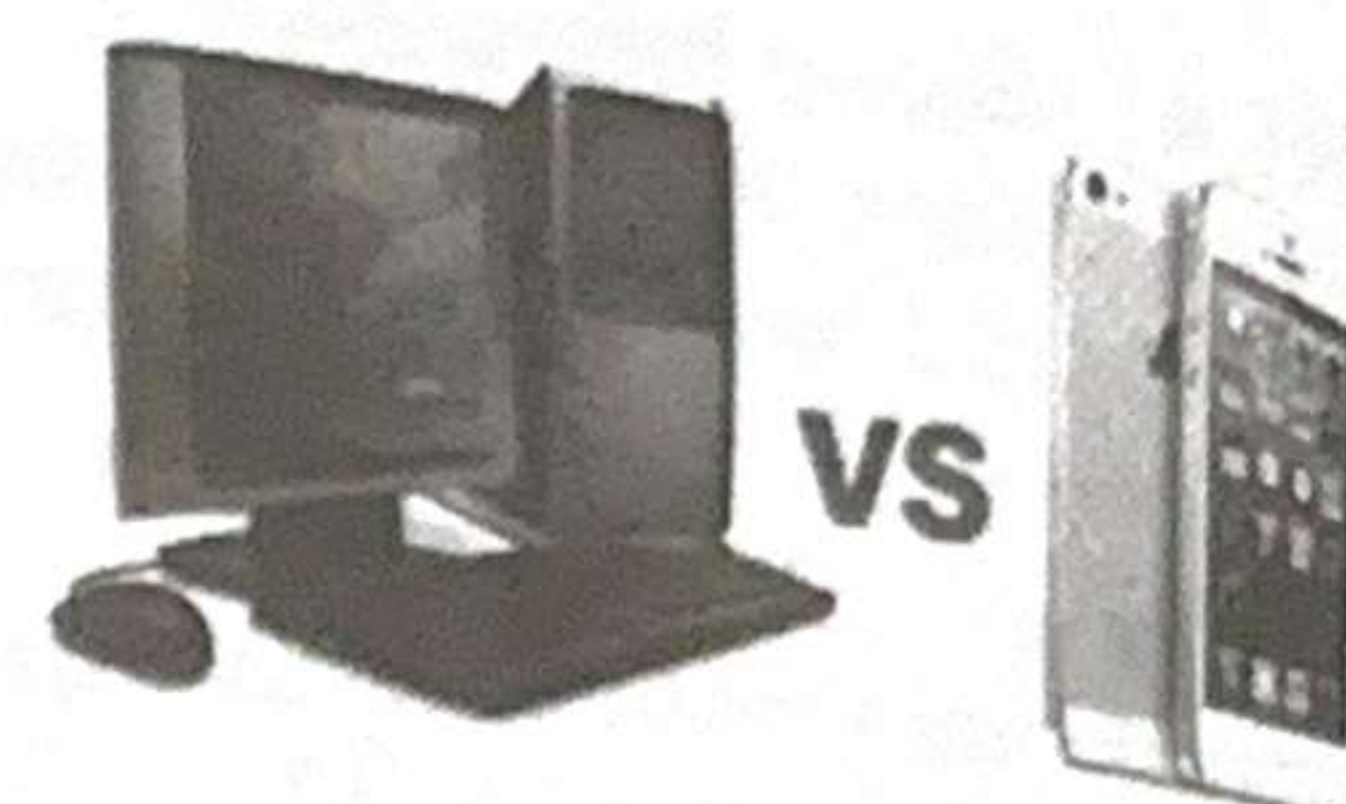
ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article recently appeared on a technology website:

As PC ownership declines, smartphones are on the rise

During the 1990s, as personal computers or 'PCs' – including desktops and laptop computers – became more user-friendly, ownership of these devices increased dramatically. In the US, households owning a PC rose from 15% in 1990 to 35% in 1997. As the internet became more popular and usable, ownership continued to rise, and by 2007, about 271 million people worldwide owned a PC.



In that same year, something incredible happened. Apple released the iPhone, the world's first modern smartphone. That year, 124 million smartphones were sold; within four years, smartphone sales surpassed those of PCs. By 2015, sales of smartphones were nearly five times higher than those of PCs.

Although PC ownership received a brief boost during the Covid-19 pandemic, when many people had to work from home, that was short-lived. In 2022, sales of PCs dropped by 20% from the previous year, and worldwide PC sales fell again in 2023 and 2024. Smartphone sales, meanwhile, have been rising by about 10% year on year, and by 2024, nearly 60% of all web traffic was from mobile devices.

Does this mean that the PC is dead? Not quite, say analysts. For people who work mostly in one place, for instance, a PC is more convenient, and for gamers who play high-end video games that require a lot of power, PCs are clearly better than phones.

In the end, analysts say, the device you choose to use is the one that works best for you.

You are members of your school technology club. Your group is discussing the rise of smartphones. You may want to talk about:

- why smartphones are so popular
- whether PCs are still useful for students
- whether smartphones will one day completely replace PCs
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you use a smartphone?
2. Do you ever use a computer for homework?
3. Do teenagers in Hong Kong spend too much time on their smartphones?
4. Do you think that you could live without a smartphone?
5. Should students be allowed to use smartphones in school?
6. Do you think schools should provide laptops for students?
7. Do you prefer to work on a PC or smartphone?
8. Should very young children be allowed to use a smartphone?